University of Glasgow: Academic Quality Processes

Professor Marc Alexander and Dr Andrew Struan
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University of Glasgow

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Overview

- Scotland's distinctive Quality Enhancement Framework
- Focus on enhancement over compliance
- Comprehensive quality ecosystem
- Student partnership approach

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Scottish HE Context

- Quality Enhancement Framework established 2003, updated 2024
- Collaborative development: Scottish Funding Council, Universities Scotland, QAA, student representatives
- Fundamental difference: prioritising enhancement over compliance auditing
- Recognition that as all staff are committed to a high quality student experience, the system should work through supportive rather than punitive processes

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Five Interconnected Elements

- Internal review
- Student partnership
- Public information
- Enhancement themes
- External review
- *Aim:* Full ecosystem where quality processes reinforce each other

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Foundational Principles

- *Completeness*: All credit-bearing and PGR provision included
  - Undergraduate and postgraduate taught
  - Research degrees
  - Collaborative programmes
  - Transnational education
- *Coherence*: Interconnected system where outputs inform other processes
- *Devolved Responsibility*: The University's staff are all held collectively responsible for maintaining academic standards

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More Core Principles

- *Objectivity*: External perspectives in every process
  - External academics on PSR panels
  - External examiners
  - Professional body accreditation
  - Student voices throughout
- *Enhancement Focus*: Beyond assurance to deliberate improvement
  - Identify and share good practice
  - Encourage innovation
  - Support teaching development

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Key Terminology

- *Academic Standards*: Level of achievement required for award
  - Aims to be constant over time and comparable across institutions
- *Academic Quality*: How effectively learning opportunities help achieve standards
  - Teaching methods
  - Assessment design
  - Learning resources
  - Student support

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Quality Enhancement Definition

- Systematic steps to improve student learning experiences
- Reactive improvement: addressing weaknesses
- Proactive development: anticipating future needs
- Evidence-based decision-making
- Experimentation and evaluation

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Three Time Periods

- *Regular Activities* (continuous)
  - Course and programme approval
  - Student feedback and representation
- *Annual Activities* (yearly reflection)
  - Annual monitoring
  - Performance data review
  - Enhancement initiatives
- *Periodic Activities* (5-6 year cycles)
  - Periodic Subject Review
  - Student-Facing Service Reviews and Graduate School Review
  - External statutory and accrediting bodies (where appropriate)

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Student Partnership Model

- Students as partners, *not* customers
- Elected class representatives with formal training
- Representation recorded on achievement records
- Staff-Student Liaison Committees (SSLCs)
  - Student majorities, ideally student chairs (or co-chairs)
  - Multiple governance levels (programme, subject, School, College, SRC)
  - Address operational and enhancement issues

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Course Evaluation System

- Mandatory questionnaire for all courses
- Standardised core questions + context-specific additions
- Required 'Summary and Response' documents
  - Demonstrates consideration of feedback
  - Shows planned actions
  - Closes the feedback loop
- Student panel members in all periodic reviews

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Annual Monitoring Process

- Cornerstone of quality framework
- Comprehensive review examining:
  - Student performance statistics
  - Progression and completion rates
  - Student and staff feedback
  - External examiner reports
  - Enhancement initiative outcomes
- Under ongoing redevelopment

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Annual Monitoring Flow

- Academic units produce Annual Monitoring Reports (AMRs)
- School Quality Officers review → School Summaries (SAMS)
- College Quality Officers review → College Summaries (CAMS)
- Academic Standards Committee reviews CAMS
- Issues addressed at appropriate level with university oversight

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External Examining System

- Four-year appointments
- Full Board of Examiners membership
- Responsibilities:
  - Review sample of assessment instruments in advance
  - Attend examination boards (at least once a year)
  - Comment on standards achieved
  - Provide comparative judgements
- Annual reports addressed direct to Principal (=President)
- Systematic institutional review with required responses

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Periodic Subject Review (PSR)

- Six-year cycle for taught provision
- External panel composition:
  - External academic specialists
  - Student representatives
  - Senior university staff
  - Professional services representation
  - External accreditators where appropriate
- Comprehensive self-evaluation required
- Extensive panel visits and stakeholder meetings

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PSR Outcomes

- Detailed analysis of strengths and development areas
- Specific enhancement recommendations
- Categorised by responsibility level
- Implementation timescales
- Follow-up monitoring at six months
- Good practice dissemination
- Detailed committee review and follow-up queries

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Graduate School Review

- Five-year cycle (four reviews + reflection year)
- Focus on research student experience
- Examines:
  - Academic assessment standards
  - Support arrangements
  - Full student lifecycle
  - Supervision quality
  - Professional development

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Professional Body Accreditation

- Additional external validation
- Periodic review visits
- Curriculum evaluation against professional competencies
- Can include:
  - Staff qualification assessment
  - Resource evaluation
  - Analysis of internal quality processes
  - Regulatory review and changes
- Drives curriculum enhancement

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Tertiary Quality Enhancement Framework (TQEF)

- New unified system for colleges and universities
- Six core principles:
  - Excellence in learning, teaching, assessment
  - Supporting student success
  - Enhancement and quality culture
  - Student engagement and partnership
  - Data and evidence
  - Externality
- Annual Self-Evaluation and Action Plan (SEAP)

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Tertiary Quality Enhancement Review (TQER)

- Launched 2024
- Single approach for all Scottish tertiary institutions
- Peer-led, enhancement-focused
- Co-created with staff and students
- External review teams evaluate against TQEF principles
- Complies with ENQA's European Standards and Guidelines (ESG)

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Integration with External Frameworks

- Scottish Credit and Qualifications Framework
- Subject Benchmark Statements
- UK Quality Code
- Bologna Process requirements
- Higher Education Achievement Records (HEAR)
- Regular international benchmarking

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Comparative Analysis: Glasgow vs Traditional UK Models

- Enhancement focus vs compliance monitoring
- Academic autonomy with systematic support
- Genuine student partnership vs consultation
- Quality embedded in academic governance
- Cyclical review balancing accountability and autonomy
- Internal ownership ensuring authenticity

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System Strengths

- Coherent integration - processes reinforce each other
- Multiple external validation mechanisms
- Internal ownership ensures sustainability
- Data-driven improvement
- Authentic student voice
- Balance of assurance and enhancement

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System Weaknesses

- You tell us!
- Substantial workload
- At least one part is being redeveloped at any given moment
- Evaluation fatigue from staff and students
- Meaningful engagement with the student voice
- Challenges of getting intelligent, integrated data at every level

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Future Directions

- Enhanced data analytics for pattern identification
- Increased international benchmarking
- Innovation in student engagement mechanisms
- Continued evolution of partnership approaches
- Integration of emerging quality enhancement practices

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Conclusion

- We aim for rigorous quality assurance through an enhancement focus
  - That respects academic autonomy
  - That ensures systematic oversight
  - That promotes continuous improvement
  - That is adaptable to different institutional contexts

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